

The Business of Politics

The leading businessman offers rare insights and revelations into his relations with the Gandhis, but much of the book is for vanity's sake



**BRUSHES WITH HISTORY:
AN AUTOBIOGRAPHY**
by KRISHNA KUMAR BIRLA
Viking
Price: Rs 650; Pages: 650

■ By Dilip Bobb

This is the autobiography of one of India's leading businessmen and yet there is very little about business. K.K. Birla's real passion was politics, specifically the Congress party and his relations with its leadership, mainly the Gandhi family—the flattering foreword is by Sonia Gandhi. Birla, 90, was a committed Congressman for most of his adult life. He was a three-term Congress (I) MP and was extremely close to Indira, Sanjay, Rajiv and Sonia. Politics was in his genes. His father, G.D. Birla, was a close associate of Mahatma Gandhi, who stayed at Birla House in Delhi, where he was assassinated. Privileged access to the pre- and post-independence leadership and close ties with the Nehru/Gandhi family gave K.K. Birla a front row seat to history and intimate contact with the makers of modern India, including many non-Congress leaders.

K.K. Babu, as he was known, was a nationalist but also an Anglophile, spending months in London. His suits and shirts came from Jermyn

Street and Savile Row. He came from India's leading business family, yet spent much of his life in political ante-rooms waiting for appointments with leaders and canvassing for a Parliament seat. He spent more time advising Sanjay Gandhi on his car project than managing many of his own companies. Yet, he was a man with a strong sense of principles, which made him a bit of a misfit in the dog-eat-dog jungle of Indian politics.

His instant access to the Gandhis, however, gave him a unique perspective and insider's knowledge of the inner workings of the party, its secrets, the back-stabbing and the decision making process. There is a wealth of information here that is fascinating and revealing, especially on Sanjay, with whom he had a close relationship. His inside account reveals a lot about

HISTORY'S FRONT ROW: Indira at a dinner with the Birlas in the 1950s



the relationship between Indira and her favourite son, the manner in which Sanjay manipulated events and people, including his own mother, who often gave in to his political whims. This book gives us a better idea of the kind of clout Sanjay wielded. Birla also reveals that in selecting an editor for his newspaper, *The Hindustan Times*, he consulted the Congress government and on one occasion, Sanjay, who suggested that his wife Maneka would make a good editor.

Where Birla's account falters is that his closeness to the Gandhi family forces him to paint them with a sympathetic brush. He criticises some of Indira's and Sanjay's actions during the Emergency, but generally pulls his punches, reserving glowing praise for both Rajiv and Sonia. As an autobiography, this book has much to offer by way of insight and personal reminiscences, but that covers less than half the book. The main problem is that this is what publishers call a vanity publication. There is a jumble of small chapters on his businesses, his daughters, in-laws, and vignettes on things that happened in his life which seemed worth recording, including his by-pass

operation, running out of petrol in the UK, and brief profiles of notables he knew and letters and greetings he exchanged with them. In that sense, *Brushes with History* is an apt title since it is a large canvas with some interesting strokes, but marred by myriad blotches of information that are of no interest to the average reader. That is the trouble with vanity publications; they obscure the wood for the trees. ■

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